to assess its long-term intentions or its potential success in implementing complex policies. In her initial statements, party chair Aung San Suu Kyi has insisted that resolving ethnic conflict remains a high priority. The difficulty for her team is that they will need to negotiate with both their own armed forces headed by Min Aung Hlaing and with the ethnic armed groups, under dozens of different commanders, to secure any long-term peace agreement. With Aung San Suu Kyi serving as State Counsellor, the ethnic armed groups are positioning themselves to demand a genuinely federal union where local rights merit utmost consideration. Some of the issues on the agenda include ethnic language education policy (South and Lall 2016), resource royalty distribution (Thet Aung Lynn and Oye 2014), land tenure (Kramer 2015), and the devolution of greater powers to State legislatures (Walaiporn and Pritchard 2016). At the same time, for ethnic armed groups themselves, the most pressing issues concern their future status after a peace deal. Many have resisted calls for disarmament and eventual demobilisation. Any disarmament, they fear, puts their people at the mercy of future Myanmar governments and they may not be able to rely on central government forces for protection. The fact that ethnic Bamar make up the majority of government troops, and that Bamar, Rakhine, and Mon are the only groups well represented in the officer ranks, is a further cause for concern. Discussion of a "union army" that draws its strength from all ethnic groups has yet to progress.

Nonetheless other political changes, especially elections, have already shifted the basis for interaction. At the start of the transition, the 7 November 2010 general election was held under deliberately constrained circumstances (see Lidauer 2012). The USDP, which emerged from the mass membership organisation created by the former military regime, needed to ensure it won the majority of seats. Along with the twenty-five per cent allocation for uniformed military personnel, this would guarantee it controlled a handbrake on radical political change. When the NLD decided to boycott the election, the USDP's position strengthened significantly. In the end, the USDP won nearly eighty per cent of seats at the union level, and also seized control of the fourteen State and Region legislatures. Its dominance of politics after the election suggested continuity with the dictatorial period. When Thein Sein appointed his first cabinet, former senior military officers held almost all of the key positions. Over time, some technocratic ministers came to take important posts. These changes did not shift the overall sense that the Myanmar government functioned with the support of the military